Session 8 (PUBLISH): Exercise sheet

Foundations of Clinical Research · Level 1 · Neudata · *#ClearDataClearImpact* · Week 8 · Saturday 19 December 2026 · online, 19:30–22:30

Name: _____ **Department:** _____

Type your answers into this Word file or print the PDF.

Part	Task	When
A	Writing exercises: fix the spin, verb ladder, results sentences, a title from your PICO	Homework
B	**Manuscript workshop 2**: check the class Q1 Results, then your own Results section and title	After section 8.1. Email your Results by 23:59 on Sunday 20 December
C	Getting published: spot the predatory journal, respond to reviewers	Homework
D	**Be the reviewer**: appraise Paper 1 and Paper 2 with the answer grid	Section 8.3, finish at home

Files you need (sent by email): the original PDFs of Paper 1 (Boulet 2024) and Paper 2 (Hyun 2023), the class Q1 Results from Session 7 (PDF), your own Results draft and your results pack.

Part A: Writing exercises (homework)

Task. Do the four exercises alone at home and write your answers in the spaces. The answers are in the solutions sheet, shared after the session.

A1. Fix the spin

Rewrite each sentence so it says only what the data and the design allow.

#	Original sentence (from the papers)	Your rewrite
a	Paper 1 (p.10), primary outcome p = 0.42, difference 13.2 ml/kg (95% CI −15.2 to 41.6): the authors base the case for a larger trial on "the non-significant trend in fluid balance reduction".	
b	Paper 2 (p.4): "a positive fluid balance on the first ICU day did not impact the 28-day mortality".	
c	Paper 2 (title): "Impact of a cumulative positive fluid balance during the first three ICU days in patients with sepsis …"	
d	Paper 1 (p.10): the protocol obtained "the lowest fluid balance on Day 5 ever published".	

A2. Climb the verb ladder

For each study, write the strongest verb its design allows.

> **Choose from:** was observed in · is associated with · may contribute to · reduced / did not reduce · causes

#	Study	Strongest honest verb
a	A case series of 12 ICU patients with septic shock who developed pulmonary oedema after large fluid volumes	
b	A cohort of 3,000 septic patients: positive fluid balance and mortality, adjusted for severity	
c	A single randomised trial of 48 patients: restrictive protocol and day-5 fluid balance	
d	Five large randomised trials and a meta-analysis, all consistent	
e	A cross-sectional survey of how completely fluid-balance charts are filled in on two ICUs	

A3. Write the results sentence (number + CI, no adjectives)

Write one sentence for each, in the style "In [whom], [outcome] was [effect] ([measure] [value], 95% CI [lower] to [upper])".

1. Paper 2, Day-3 cohort: 28-day mortality, positive vs negative fluid balance, HR 1.56, 95% CI 1.10 to 2.22, P = 0.012.
2. Paper 1: death by day 28, 6/24 (restrictive) vs 6/24 (control), relative risk 1.0, 95% CI 0.38 to 2.66.
3. Paper 2, Day-1 cohort: HR 1.17, 95% CI 0.85 to 1.60, P = 0.354.

A4. A title from your PICO

Formula: **[Design] of [Intervention / exposure] vs [Comparator] in [Population]: effect on / association with [Outcome]**. 10–16 words, design stated, no "impact", "novel", "first".

My PICO: P _____ I/E _____ C _____ O _____

Working title: _____

Word count: ____ Design named? ☐ Calibrated verb (association for observational designs)? ☐

Part B: Manuscript workshop 2: improve your Results section

Task. First, check the class Q1 Results from Session 7 alone (7 minutes). Use the four checks below, note every problem you find with your fix, and write a working title for Q1. Then run the same checks on your own Results draft and write your own working title (6 minutes). Be ready to share what you found when the instructor asks. After the session, finish your draft and email it by 23:59 on Sunday 20 December 2026 (see "What to send").

The four checks

1. **Numbers:** every number agrees with the results pack (pack Q1 for the class draft, your own pack for your draft).
2. **Tables and figure:** title, units, n and abbreviations. Each one can be read without the text.
3. **Words:** no interpretation, no "trend", no causal verbs.
4. **Working title:** 10–16 words, the design named, "associated" for an observational design.

The class Q1 Results

Check	Problem I found	My fix
Numbers		
Tables and figure		
Words		

Working title for Q1: _____

You receive the improved class Q1 Results as a PDF after the session.

My own Results draft

My working title: _____

Final check before you send

- ☐ Every number agrees with your results pack
- ☐ Percentages with denominators, estimates with 95% CIs
- ☐ Crude and adjusted estimates both reported
- ☐ Table 1 and one main table or figure that stand alone
- ☐ No interpretation and no causal words
- ☐ Working title and AI-use statement

Other sections (taught in 8.1, optional to submit)

If you have time, add any of these in the same file. Trainers give feedback on them.

- **Introduction:** three paragraphs: known, not known, aim
- **Discussion:** answer, compare (e.g. with Paper 2), explain, limitations with their direction, implications, conclusion
- **Abstract:** structured, 250 words or fewer, numbers identical to your Results

What to send

`Surname_Firstname_Results_QN.docx`, emailed to your reviewer and to the instructor (myluong1710@gmail.com) **by 23:59 on Sunday 20 December 2026 (Vietnam time)**. Then the peer review (`Peer_Review_Instructions.pdf`): your review is due on Wednesday 30 December 2026, and your revised Results section and response letter (`Response_to_Reviewers_Template.docx`) on Saturday 9 January 2027.

Part C: Getting published (homework)

Task. Do C1 and C2 alone at home and write your answers in the spaces. The answers are in the solutions sheet, shared after the session.

C1. Spot the predatory journal

1. Find the red flags in this (invented) invitation. How many can you find?

> **From:** editorial.board.gjcmr@freemail.com
>
> **Subject:** Invitation to publish in our esteemed journal!!
>
> Dear Respected Professor/Doctor,
>
> Greetings! We have gone through your excellent article and are delighted to invite you to submit to the *Global Journal of Clinical Medicine, Nursing, Engineering and Management Research*. We publish all areas of science.
>
> Our journal has an Impact Factor of 9.2 (International Universal Index). We guarantee peer review within 48 hours and publication in 5 days. Processing charges will be communicated after acceptance. Special discount this week only!
>
> Kindly submit your manuscript by replying to this e-mail.

Red flags I found: _____

2. Which journal would you trust? For each (invented) profile, write *Trust / Check further / Avoid* and one reason.

Journal profile	Your verdict	Reason
J1: Indexed in MEDLINE (confirmed in the NLM Catalog), editor names verifiable at universities, fee (APC) shown on the website, median 9 weeks to first decision, uses CONSORT/STROBE checklists.		
J2: Says "indexed in Google Scholar and Index Copernicus", promises acceptance in 72 hours, no fee information, editorial board photos without affiliations.		
J3: Open access, listed in DOAJ, small society journal, no impact factor yet, clear peer-review and retraction policy.		
J4: Its name differs by one word from a well-known journal. The website address is different from the real journal's. It e-mailed you first.		

3. Three checks you can always do: Think.Check.Submit checklist · DOAJ (Directory of Open Access Journals) · NLM Catalog ("currently indexed in MEDLINE"). You can also ask your librarian.

C2. Responding to reviewers

Imagine your own proposed study has been completed and submitted. Write a response row for each comment (thank, answer, say exactly what changed). One of them deserves a polite rebuttal.

#	Reviewer comment	Our response	Change made (page, line)
R1.1	"The title says your intervention *improves* outcomes, but this is an observational study."		
R1.2	"Please report the main result with a confidence interval, not only the p-value."		
R1.3	"Text and Table 2 give different numbers of patients analysed (212 vs 208)."		
R2.1	"Please add 1-year mortality." (Your protocol followed patients to day 28 only.)		

Tone checklist: ☐ thanked the reviewer ☐ answered every point ☐ said where the manuscript changed ☐ disagreed only with evidence, politely

Part D: Be the reviewer (answer grid)

Task. In the session, appraise both papers alone (6 minutes). For Paper 1 answer questions 4, 5, 7, 8 and 9. For Paper 2 answer questions 4, 5, 8 and 9. For each question tick Yes, No or Can't tell, write the page and add a one-line note. "Where to look" tells you the pages. Be ready to share your answer when the instructor asks. At home, answer the other questions (1–3, 6 and 10) for both papers.

"Can't tell" is a good answer when the paper does not say.

	Paper	Design
Paper 1	Boulet N, et al. *Crit Care* 2024;28:429 (restrictive strategy targeting non-resuscitative fluids, OPTIFLUID)	Randomised controlled pilot trial, 48 patients analysed
Paper 2	Hyun D-G, et al. *Ann Intensive Care* 2023;13:105 (cumulative positive fluid balance in the first three ICU days)	Propensity-score-matched cohort from a sepsis registry, 2516 patients

> **Page numbers** are the journal's own page numbers printed at the top of each page ("Page X of 13" for Paper 1, "Page X of 9" for Paper 2). Use the original (unannotated) PDF.

Where to look

Question	Paper 1 (RCT): pages	Paper 2 (cohort): pages
1 Question	Abstract (p.1), last paragraph of Background (p.3)	Abstract (p.1), end of Background (p.2)
2 Design	Title (p.1), "Trial design and oversight" (p.3)	Title (p.1), Methods (pp.2–3)
3 Participants	"Patients" (p.3), flow chart Fig. 1 (p.5), Discussion limitations (p.10)	"Data source and patient selection" (p.2), Results first paragraph (p.3)
4 Comparison groups	"Randomization and blinding" (p.3), Table 1 (p.6)	"Propensity score matching" (pp.2–3), Table 1 (pp.5–6), text p.4
5 Bias	"Randomization and blinding" (p.3), Discussion (p.8)	Methods (pp.2–3), Discussion limitations (pp.7–8)
6 Outcome	"Outcomes" (p.4)	"Propensity score matching and outcomes" (p.3)
7 Numbers	"Primary outcome" (p.6), Table 3 (p.10)	Abstract (p.1), "Outcomes" (p.4)
8 Words vs design	Abstract conclusion (p.1), Discussion (pp.8, 10), Conclusions (p.11)	Title (p.1), Abstract conclusion (p.1), Discussion (pp.4, 7), Conclusions (p.8)
9 Limitations	Discussion (pp.8–10)	Discussion (pp.7–8)
10 Use	Your judgement (whole paper)	Your judgement (whole paper)

Answer grid (one copy per paper)

Paper: 1 / 2

#	Question (simplified appraisal checklist)	Yes	No	Can't tell	Page	Notes (one line)
1	**Question**: Can you write the study's PICO in one line?	☐	☐	☐		P: … I/E: … C: … O: …
2	**Design**: What is the design, and is it the right one for the question?	☐	☐	☐		
3	**Participants**: Who was included, and who was left out? Would your patients have been included?	☐	☐	☐		
4	**Comparison groups**: Were the groups similar at the start (Table 1)? How was this achieved (randomisation / matching / adjustment)?	☐	☐	☐		
5	**Bias**: Who knew which group patients were in (blinding)? Could that change the outcome?	☐	☐	☐		
6	**Outcome**: Was there ONE pre-specified primary outcome, measured the same way in both groups?	☐	☐	☐		
7	**Numbers**: What is the main result as an effect size with 95% CI? Is the CI narrow or wide?	☐	☐	☐		Effect: …… 95% CI: ……
8	**Words vs design**: Do the conclusions match the design ("associated" vs "caused", no "trend" for p = 0.42)?	☐	☐	☐		Words found:
9	**Limitations**: Are the main limitations stated honestly? Name one the authors missed.	☐	☐	☐		Missed:
10	**Use**: Would this change practice in your unit? Why / why not?	☐	☐	☐		

My verdict in one sentence: _____

One thing I would copy into my own proposal: _____

Hints if you are stuck

- **Q1:** the PICO is usually in the last paragraph of the Introduction ("we aimed to …"). Is the paper's outcome the same as in our running question (28-day mortality)?
- **Q4:** a randomised trial makes groups similar by chance. A cohort can only match or adjust for what was measured. Find the sentence that says which.
- **Q5:** who decided how much fluid each patient received, and did they know the group?
- **Q7:** look for "difference" or "HR" followed by brackets. Does the interval include 0 (for a difference) or 1 (for a ratio)?
- **Q8:** search for the words *impact, show, trend, ever, regardless*.